18300 in the dark and then move along a small stream to get to the dead ground (blind spot) ahead of the Kumaonis to the south of the mountain before first light. At the same time, a second column, also accompanied by an artillery observer, was climbing along the left side of Valley West with the intention of linking up with the first column. A third column was proceeding directly, while a fourth column was also making its way towards the upper part of Valley East, from where it hoped to cut across the depression and get behind Rezang-la. All the columns were to exploit the topography that afforded plenty of cover, and set up mortar and MMG positions as close to the three Kumaonis positions.

At 1 a.m., Naik Hukum Chand, the 2IC of No. 8 Platoon took out a patrol in front of his position. After two hours of being on a listening watch, the men could hear noises that suggested a large body of men was on the move. Hukum Chand fired a red Very light that illuminated a Chinese column slowly moving towards his platoon position. The patrol commander immediately sent a man to inform Shaitan Singh. The patrol fell back to its defended locality, where every man had by then been put on stand-to.

Meanwhile, when the Very light had been fired, No. 7 Platoon had also reported seeing some movement in front of their position. They too were on stand-to, their weapons at the ready. Shaitan Singh also alerted Naib Subedar Ram Chand of No. 9 Platoon, who asked his own patrols to fall back immediately. Hence by 4 a.m., all three Kumaonis platoons were in position, peering into the darkness for signs of the Chinese. Some additional men had arrived the previous day for a routine Cadre Test (for promotion) and were billeted at the company location. They had brought with them 2-inch mortars that were now available with the company commander. Shortly thereafter, Shaitan Singh fired an illumination flare that lit up the entire area. In front of No. 8 and No. 7 Platoon, the Chinese could be seen preparing to launch their attack. All three Kumaonis platoons opened fire simultaneously, causing heavy Chinese casualties and forcing them to go to ground.

Mugger Hill was the closest post to Rezang-la and was manned by Delta Company under Major Jatar Singh. He immediately reported the sound of gunfire from the direction of Rezang-la and by 4.30 a.m. had dispatched a four-man patrol under Naik Roop Ram to ascertain the actual position.